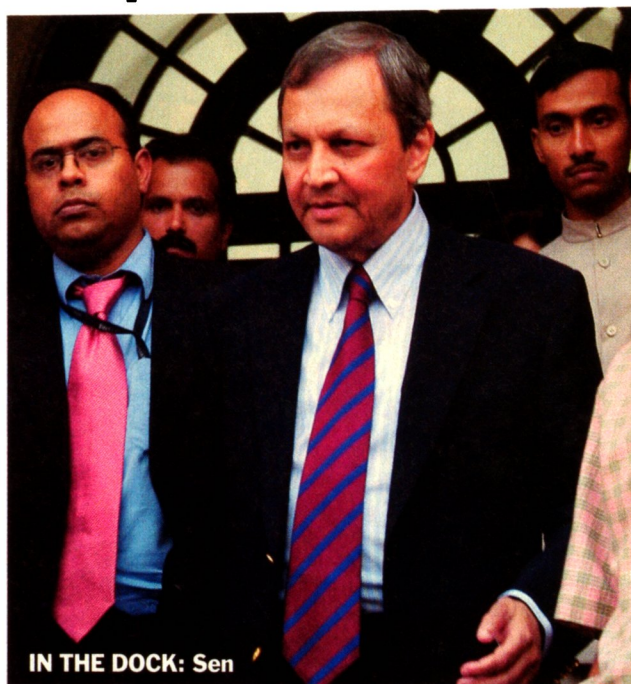


DELHI Breach of privilege is the last thing one would have expected from veteran diplomat Ronen Sen, India's ambassador to the US, who is known to measure every word he speaks. But as he appeared before the Privilege Committee of Lok Sabha on October 29 in response to its summons, he was guarded in his approach.

Realising the political sensitivity of the nuclear issue and the furore his remarks caused, as Sen explained his alleged remarks to a cross-section of lawmakers in the committee, he denied calling them "headless chickens". He tendered an unqualified apology reiterating that the remark was meant for the media in the heat of the Indo-US nuclear deal. Sen had said in an interview, "The deal has been approved by the Indian Cabinet. So why do you have all this running around like headless

Diplomat on the Mat



chickens, looking for a comment here or a comment there, and these little storms in a tea-cup?"

The Indian envoy is believed to have told the committee that it was not an interview but a mobile

phone conversation which was off the record. He added that it was a casual remark, one that he often used even in conversations with his wife.

His undiplomatic outbursts aside, this is

perhaps for the first time that a serving diplomat has been summoned for breach of privilege. Sen will now face a volley of questions from the Rajya Sabha Privileges Committee, where the sailing may be a little more tough.

Sen, a retired 1966 batch IFS officer served in Rajiv Gandhi's PMO and was rewarded for his "back rooming skills" with the prized Washington posting. The envoy, whose elevated status has more to do with his direct connections with the powers that be, has ensured that he stays put in Washington despite a fatigued diplomatic innings, at least till the end of his term in March. In the process, he has caused considerable embarrassment to his benefactors in the Government, and certainly damaged his own unblemished record as a diplomat.

by Saurabh Shukla

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

With no party wanting to get into serious debate in Parliament on the nuclear issue, there seems to be an all-party consensus to keep the winter session brief so that everyone can converge in Gujarat to resume battle there.

VOICES

"We have not reached the end of the road on the nuclear deal. Efforts are on to evolve a broad-based national consensus."

Manmohan Singh, prime minister

"If BJP wants to prove it is a party with a difference, it must expel all its top leaders including Atal Bihari Vajpayee and L.K. Advani."

K.N. Govindacharya, former BJP general secretary

"Quota legislation cannot be challenged on the basis of non-identification of 27 per cent beneficiaries and questioning the data based on 1931 census."

Ram Jethmalani, advocate and former Union law minister

"The Congress has not ruled nor had any active participation in the Uttar Pradesh government for 19 years. It won't gain any political significance even in the next 15 years."

Rajnath Singh, BJP president

"The national selectors have played a planned game. Dumping a devoted cricketer like Rahul Dravid reflects the degeneration that has come to dominate Indian cricket."

Sandeep Patil, former cricketer